



Here to stay: Nepal ended a 12-year wait for a third T20 World Cup win by beating Scotland in Mumbai, having earlier pushed England close, backed by rapturous fans (**facing page**) who transformed every match into a celebration. PTI & AFP

Netherlands captain Scott Edwards said. "But to get to the next level, we need more opportunities against Test-playing nations. As Associates, you often only face them at World Cups. That's the reality. The better we perform at these events, the stronger our voice becomes and, hopefully, that leads to more fixtures outside tournaments."

Preparation divide

Full-member teams sharpened themselves through bilateral series. Associate nations, by contrast, were left to stitch together preparation as best they could, often relying on short training camps and limited windows of competition.

Italy played three matches against Ireland and one against Namibia in Dubai in January 2026 before travelling to India. Several Dutch players arrived early in Mumbai for individual preparation before the full squad trained at Chennai's Super Kings Academy.

For each opponent, these teams leaned heavily on data and video analysis to compensate for limited match exposure. For USA all-rounder Mohammad Mohsin, that dynamic can even tilt slightly in their favour.

"Not playing regularly against full-member nations can work both ways. We study them throughout the year on TV, through video and

analysis. But they don't always have much data on us. That can be an advantage," Mohsin said.

The margins at this World Cup have shown that the gap is narrowing, but it also requires greater exposure, infrastructure and funding.

Under the ICC's 2024-2027 revenue cycle, India will receive roughly 40 per cent of the global body's earnings, about \$231 million annually. Of the ICC's estimated \$600 million annual revenue during this period, nearly \$533 million will be distributed among the 12 full members, while Associate nations will share approximately \$67 million.

The gulf is huge. But, as Italy head coach John Davison pointed out, it is not only about the money. In a football-dominated nation, the dream of reaching the sports pages and expanding coverage beyond the Winter Olympics fuels these players.

No wonder players squeeze time out of their day jobs to follow their passion. Some hope to catch the attention of franchise owners and break into major leagues, but they know it is not easy given the limited exposure to high-level competitive cricket.

Structural reform

That is something that needs immediate attention. In previous ICC

events, teams like the Netherlands, Scotland, UAE and Oman have proved their mettle, but back home there has been little change in terms of exposure. For several teams, the domestic structure is not streamlined.

That made this edition of the T20 World Cup crucial. Each time smaller teams caught the attention of stakeholders, they hoped it would translate into structural change. They at least allowed themselves to dream of more equitable treatment.

But it is easier said than done.

As Davison, a former Canada international, suggested, Associate nations expect structural changes. Teams like Italy would "love to play more cricket" and develop turf facilities back home, but funding and programming depend on administrators and ICC support.

That is where unity comes in. Cricket Scotland CEO Trudy Lindblade revealed that when not competing, Associate nations help each other stay afloat and keep the game going.

"We (the Associate members) meet, and one of the things that we used to have was someone within the ICC who could help bring us together. That would be something that, if we could look at having again, would make sure that we are working together to build the game and grow the game," Lindblade said.